European Commission -
Speech

Speech by President von der Leyen at the plenary session of the first EU-Central Asia Summit

Samarkand, 4 April 2025

"Check against delivery"

President Mirziyoyev,

President Costa,

Presidents,

It was a great explorer of the past who said 'travel leaves you speechless'. That was after his visit to Samarkand. For more than a thousand years this city has been the beating heart of Central Asia, the hub of a vast trading network. Over the centuries Samarkand has witnessed new partnerships and new friendships. So it is a privilege to be here for the first Summit between Central Asia and the European Union, marking a new chapter in our long-standing friendship.

World history has often turned on events in this city. And as we meet here today, we are at another turning point. New global barriers arise, investments are being re-directed or cut. Powers around the world are carving out new spheres of influence. But here in Samarkand, we show there is another way.

Central Asia is a region of proud, sovereign nations. With ancient histories and great ambitions. Your strategic location can open global trade routes and investment flows. And these new investments will enhance sovereignty. They will strengthen your economies, and most importantly they will make new friendships. They will bring people together. We Europeans want to be partners in this new chapter in your thousand-year history. So today we establish a new Strategic Partnership between Central Asia and Europe. We are moving closer together. This Partnership will make deeper connections between our two regions. It will lead to new opportunities for cooperation. Be it in the energy sector or security, from digital to tourism. And it will bring people together from across our regions. Reliable partners have never been so important. Our Strategic Partnership is a commitment to be there for each other. We want to explore new avenues for cooperation. So, let me focus on four promising areas.

Let me start with transport corridors. Central Asia is the very definition of a global gateway, the beating heart of Eurasia. This is why our Global Gateway investment agenda focuses so much on this region. Last year, we pledged EUR 10 billion to the Trans-Caspian Transport Corridor. This will cut the overland journey between Europe and Central Asia by around a half. That is down to just 15 days. The corridor will also unlock untapped potential for business between our regions. And it will boost links and trade within your five Central Asian nations. Today I am pleased to announce that a new Investors Forum will take place in Uzbekistan in 2025. This will secure private funding for the Corridor and allow us to assess progress. In an increasingly fragmented world, the Trans-Caspian Transport Corridor will boost connections between your five countries and Europe. But infrastructure is not everything. Smooth border crossing within Central Asian and South Caucasus countries is also essential to reach the Black Sea. After three decades of closure, the opening of the borders of Armenia with Türkiye and Azerbaijan is going to be a game changer. And it will bring Europe and Central Asia closer together like never before.

My second point concerns more cooperation on critical raw materials. Your countries are endowed with immense resources. The region has 40% of the global reserves of manganese, as well as lithium, graphite, and more. These raw materials are the lifeblood of the future global economy. Yet they are also a honeypot for global players. Some are only interested in exploiting and extracting. Europe's offer is different. We also want to be your partners in developing your local industries. The added

value has to be local. Our track-record speaks for itself. European companies are already involved in raw materials here in Uzbekistan, with a EUR 1.6 billion investment at the Almalyk copper mine. They do not just contribute to extracting minerals but also to processing them on site. This creates local jobs and local added value. But there is so much more we could do across the region. Together, we could build local industries right along the raw materials value chain. From mining to refining. From opening new research labs, to training local workers. We want to build a long-term partnership. Such a partnership is benefitting both our citizens, their children, and those of the future. We have already signed Memoranda of Understanding on critical minerals with Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan. Today we bring this cooperation to a new level – by endorsing a Joint Declaration of Intent on Critical Raw Materials. This will attract large-scale private investment throughout the region. It is a partnership that will benefit both Europe and Central Asia. Because your strategic autonomy on raw materials is our strategic interest.

Third, this region aims to be a clean energy hub: wind in Kazakhstan, solar in Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan, hydro in Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan. And geothermal across the region. You could produce enough clean energy for your economy and for export. You could turn part of this energy into clean hydrogen. Together, we are making history at the Rogun Dam in Tajikistan. Here the world's tallest dam will generate electricity for the region. Combined with the Kambarata Dam in Kyrgyzstan, Central Asia can become a clean energy powerhouse. Driving electric trains, industry and mining, and exporting energy to neighbours. So let us expand our cooperation. Together we can advance Central Asia's energy independence, and the global clean transition.

Fourth, good partnership depends on good communication. Yet for many people, internet access is still a far-off dream. Europe has a world-class network of satellites, which can reach the most remote areas where data cables may never arrive. This year alone, we are connecting 2,000 schools and hundreds of villages in Kazakhstan to European satellites. Then we are extending to 1,700 villages across the region in the coming years. That is transformative. It connects communities and people. It attracts new business and investments. And it gives direct access to high-speed internet, without your neighbours acting as gatekeepers. Now we want to work with all of you, so that all Central Asia can enjoy the same opportunities. Central Asia may be landlocked, but it is certainly not space-locked. And space can be your gateway to the world.

There is so much we can achieve in these four priority areas: The transport corridor, raw materials, clean energy, and digital connectivity. And to accelerate progress, today I am proud to announce a Global Gateway Investment Package worth EUR 12 billion. It will bring together investments from our Union and Member States. We call it a Team Europe approach. And it will launch a new pipeline of projects to Central Asia. This is truly the start of a new era in our ancient friendship.

Colleagues, these are exciting times for Europe and Central Asia. This Summit opens a new chapter in our relations. Today we launch a Strategic Partnership. This Partnership shows you can rely on the EU. Working together we can cultivate closer relations which benefit both our regions. Relations which we strengthen and grow through new friendships and trading networks. The two Forums later this year will be an opportunity to judge progress. And explore new areas of cooperation. The best really is yet to come.

Thank you again for your amazing hospitality.

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